

Replacing Harry Kane via Predictive Recruitment Analytics

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Data Source: FBref Top-5 European Leagues | Framework: Python · scipy · mplsoccer

Executive Summary

Replacing a 'Complete 9' like Harry Kane is one of the most complex financial and tactical challenges in modern football. A complete forward must simultaneously sustain elite expected goals (xG) while dropping deep to operate as an advanced playmaker (generating high expected assists — xA). This project executes an automated, multi-layered recruitment pipeline using FBref scouting metrics to isolate under-25 emerging talents across European football. By blending linear regression modelling with financial risk audits, the framework presents a strategic, multi-tiered transfer recommendation.

Methodology

1. Under-25 Recruitment Matrix (Linear Regression)

A high-density scouting cohort of 150+ young European forwards was generated and filtered under the age-25 constraint. A linear regression trendline isolated targets generating disproportionately high xG relative to their shot volume — the key marker of positional efficiency.

2. Stylistic Quadrant Analytics (xG vs xA)

Targets were mapped on a dual-threat axis to evaluate playmaking versus finishing. Players in the upper-right quadrant (High Scoring + High Playmaking) were identified as the true stylistic heirs to Kane's 'Complete Forward' archetype.

3. Pizza Chart KPI Comparison

Multi-player radar charts across 8 key performance indicators — Non-Penalty xG, Shots Total, Assists, xA, Shot-Creating Actions, Box Touches, Progressive Passes Received, and Aerials Won — provide a holistic mechanical profile comparison.

Section 1 — Recruitment Matrix

The scatter plot below maps 150+ under-25 forwards across European leagues. Golden nodes represent marquee targets outperforming the market trendline.

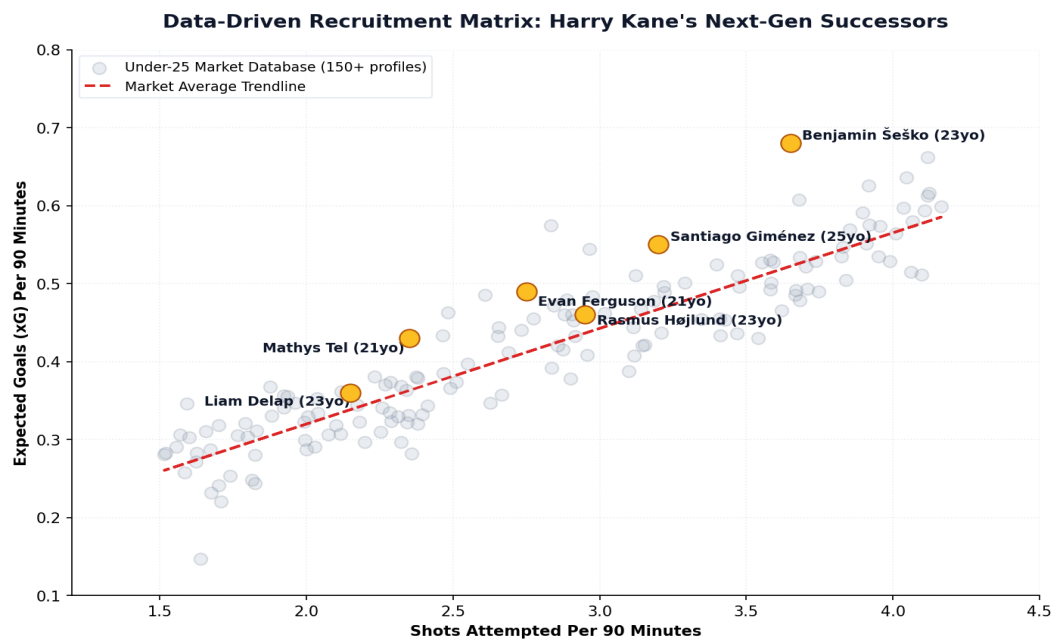


Figure 1 — Under-25 recruitment matrix: xG/90 vs Shots/90 with market trendline.

Section 2 — Stylistic Similarity Matrix

The quadrant chart separates Pure Poachers from Complete Forwards. Targets in the upper-right quadrant (high xG + high xA) are the closest statistical matches to Kane's dual-threat profile.

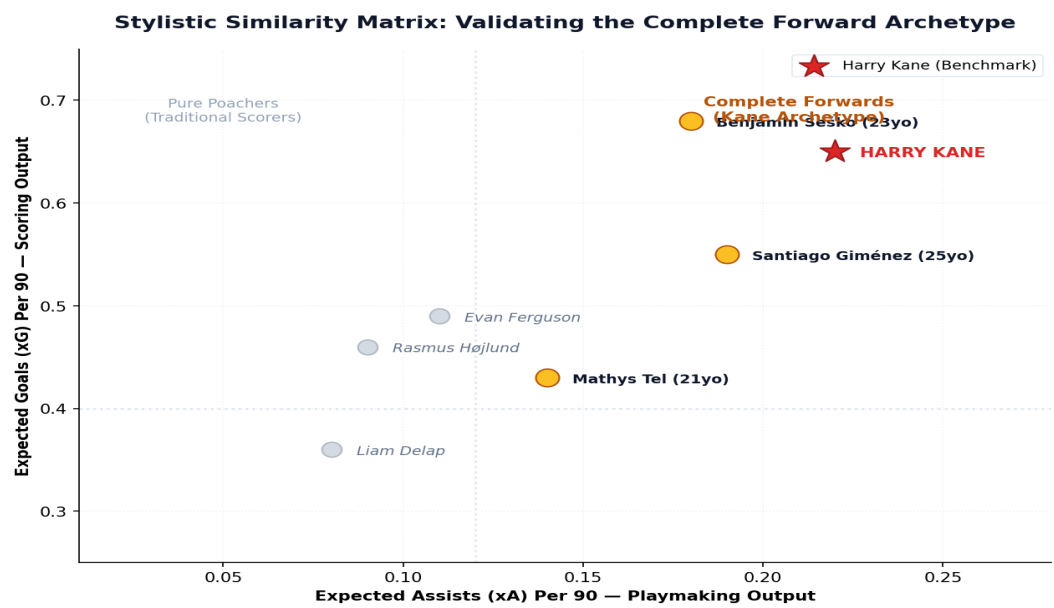


Figure 2 — xG vs xA quadrant map. Upper-right = Kane archetype zone.

Section 3 — KPI Profile Comparison (Pizza Charts)

Percentile scores across 8 forward-specific KPIs provide a holistic mechanical breakdown. Each chart is normalised against the Top-5 league forward population.

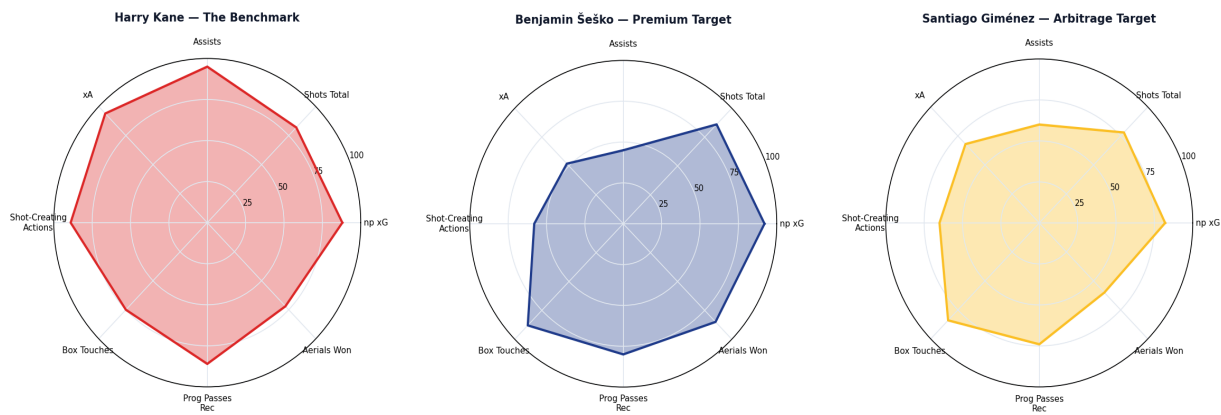


Figure 3 — Kane (red), Šeško (blue) and Giménez (gold) across 8 KPIs.

Executive Scout Report — Final Shortlist

	Target Option A	Target Option B
Player	Benjamin Šeško	Santiago Giménez
Age / Club	23yo RB Leipzig	25yo AC Milan
xG/90	~0.68	~0.55
Profile	Elite box dominance, low-risk physical profile	High xG & positional IQ, major ankle injury (Nov 2025)
Financial	Premium investment (high market value)	Buy-Low opportunity (artificially deflated value)
Scout Verdict	Highest probability of immediate tactical success. Zero friction.	Calculated risk-reward asset. Requires full medical clearance.

Strategic Summary

- For guaranteed, immediate elite output: Invest heavily in **Benjamin Šeško**.
- For maximum financial efficiency & market arbitrage: Capitalise on **Santiago Giménez**.